

AHI 101 — Week 6 Make: How Machines Read

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Text Analyzed: “Ain’t I a Woman?” by Sojourner Truth (1851 speech, Akron Women’s Rights Convention)

Voyant Analysis Summary

Using Voyant, I examined word frequency, trends across segments, and the Cirrus word cloud. The most frequent words were rights, woman, sojourner, ain’t, and women. The repetition of woman and rights confirms that the speech centers on gender and political recognition. The trends view showed that rights peaks in the middle of the text, while woman increases toward the later segments, suggesting a shift from biography to direct argument. The word cloud visually amplified this emphasis, with woman and rights dominating the field.

Voyant helped me see structural emphasis. It quantified repetition and showed how certain terms cluster in particular sections. However, it treated the speech as a dataset. It could not distinguish between irony, grief, or theological reversal. It showed patterns but did not explain their force.

GPT Analysis Summary

Prompt: “Give me a literary analysis of the text.”

GPT produced a rhetorical and thematic interpretation. It discussed repetition, embodiment, intersection of race and gender, tone shifts, and biblical references. It interpreted “Ain’t I a woman?” as both a logical challenge and moral confrontation. The analysis read the speech as a cohesive argument shaped by lived experience.

However, GPT did not show how it derived those interpretations unless prompted further. Its authority comes from fluency rather than visible method.

Comparison

Voyant imagines meaning as measurable frequency and distribution. Importance equals repetition. GPT imagines meaning as coherence and theme. Importance equals interpretive synthesis. Voyant is transparent but silent about significance. GPT is interpretive but opaque about process.

Reflection

This assignment made me realize that machines “read” according to their design. Voyant reads by counting and mapping. It assumes that meaning emerges from pattern density. This helps reveal emphasis and structure, especially in a speech built on repetition. But it flattens emotional intensity into data points. It cannot feel the grief in the line about children sold into slavery, nor can it recognize the strategic power of irony.

GPT reads by generating interpretation that resembles human literary analysis. It organizes themes and articulates connections across the text. This feels closer to classroom discussion. Yet it performs understanding rather than demonstrating it. It does not expose its evidence trail unless asked.

What we gain from machine reading is scale and speed. Patterns become visible instantly. What we lose is situated judgment. Neither tool experiences the historical weight of a formerly enslaved woman speaking in 1851. Meaning changes depending on method. Voyant fragments the text into units. GPT reconstructs it into argument. Human reading, however, still decides why those patterns and arguments matter.

Attribution and AI Use Statement

Text: Sojourner Truth, “Ain’t I a Woman?” 1851 speech, public domain

Tools used: Voyant Tools and ChatGPT

GPT prompt: “Give me a literary analysis of the text.”

Voyant limitation: Cannot interpret tone, irony, or historical stakes

GPT limitation: Does not reveal reasoning process and may overgeneralize without textual prompting

Summary

Documents

Phrases

?

Contexts

Bubblelines

Collocates

?

This corpus has 1 document with 627 total words and 295 unique word forms. Created 6 seconds ago.

Vocabulary Density: 0.470

Readability Index: 8.418

Average Words Per Sentence: 16.5

Most frequent words in the corpus:

- rights (10); woman (9); sojourner (6); ain't (6); women (5)

rights woman sojourner ain't women

Born into slavery in...

36

?

Clear

Granularity:

Separate Lines for Terms ☐

Voyant Tools, Stefan Sinclair & Geoffrey Rockwell (© 2026) Privacy v. 2026-02-28 | Voyant Consortium

Cirrus

Terms

Links

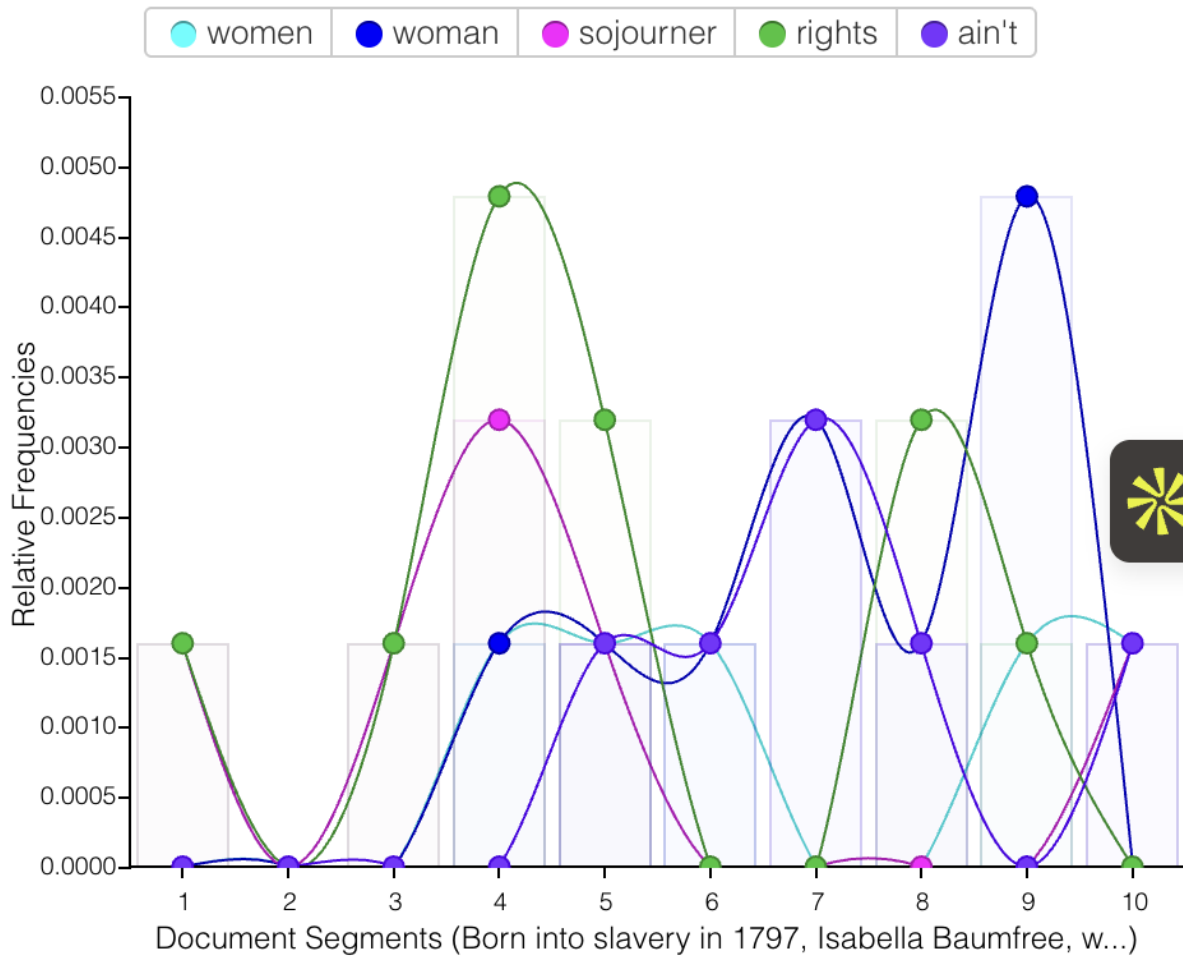
?

The word cloud features a central cluster of large, bold words including 'woman', 'man', 'rights', 'truth', 'sojourner', and 'isabella'. Surrounding these are numerous other words of varying sizes, such as 'slavery', 'ain't', 'what's', 'named', 'delivered', 'involved', 'movement', 'place', 'best', 'turn', 'god', 'later', 'little', 'sold', 'old', 'head', 'negroes', '1883', 'let', 'american', 'became', 'forced', 'convention', 'changed', 'carriages', 'children', 'come', 'saying', 'look', 'new', 'got', 'master', 'york', 'men', 'women's', 'akron', '1851', 'away', 'christ', 'ohio', 'talking', 'women', and 'men'. The words are arranged in a circular pattern, with some words appearing multiple times.

Terms:

Trends

Document Terms



Reset

Display